As the war continued, Myitkyina's ordinary business — trade, education, bureaucracy and transport — started to wilt. Munitions and personnel from elsewhere were originally brought in by rail until trains were attacked and the tracks sabotaged. Then boats were used, but they too were vulnerable to audacious KIA raids. Eventually, supplies and reinforcements were brought in by air.

The consequences of this war were felt deeply by the people of Kachin State and adjacent areas of northern Shan State, as explained by Hedström in this volume. While older people had direct memories of the effects of such conflict, an entire generation of local youth, including young women, had been raised under the relatively benign conditions of the ceasefire. They may have learned to resent central government impositions — the learning of the Burmese language in schools, the prominence of Buddhist ceremony in national life, the perception that their opportunities were limited by their ethnicity — and yet most had also enjoyed the benefits of a booming local economy. Myitkyina before the war was a key hub for education, business and cultural initiatives. It also enjoyed increasingly strong links with other areas of northern Myanmar, especially as better roads were constantly under construction, and new areas opened up for mining, logging and hydro-electricity projects. These routes served multiple purposes, especially for the many companies trading with counterparts in China (see Egreteau 2012).

China figured in the wartime calculations in other ways. Under the ceasefire, the KIA reinforced its fixed bases along the Chinese border, setting up relatively independent governance. Under the auspices of what was called "Kachin State Special Region 2", the KIA-controlled territories administered their own affairs and cultivated close ties with authorities across the border in China, including at the political level. They established casinos as one means of earning revenue, while the KIA also levied taxes on passing cross-border trade. When the war erupted, this access to China proved more valuable than ever, offering a way for the KIA to interact with the rest of the world. While the Chinese government is wary of any perception that it actively supports Myanmar's ethnic armed groups, it has also worked assiduously to ensure these groups are not overwhelmed by Tatmadaw firepower. China's double game is a significant factor along the entire length of this mountainous frontier.

That double game is also apparent in the Kokang Region in northern Shan State, where outbreaks of violence in 2009 and 2015 have shifted the terms of local government. The Kokang, whose armed group is more formally